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POLITICS

Boiled Frogs: A Case Study of One of Global Politics' Most Haunting Autocratic Takeovers & the Quiet Revelations it Makes About Modern Democracy

Drawing on Ram Chandra Guha's comparison of Mussolini's Italy and Modi's India, this long read examines how democracies slide into authoritarianism not through sudden rupture but through incremental normalisation — and what the historical record of regimes that did end tells us about the one we are in.

BY KANIKA SOLANKI

Nearly three years ago now, in an article for Scroll , Ram Chandra Guha, in what remains, 3 years hence, an impeccable & scathing critique of the Bhartiya Janata Party's neo fascist politics, managed to identify & illustrate a congruence between Mussolini's Italy & what he called 'Modi's India', that - if you care to take a closer look at - reveals something teeth gnashingly ugly about not just the Indian Democracy or what it has become in the years since it was so founded, but about the very structure of the modern democracy itself.

It is imminent to mention here that the foundation of the following case was, as a matter of fact, not an investigative report at all, but an opinion piece, one that sought to remember & commemorate the most significant dictatorships of postmodern history, not for what they were but for what their legacy signifies: their end. But the only evidence we have to the fact that they did end has been provided by those who survived them. And isn't it convenient that through all the years of history that can be found squashed into our school textbooks, the good guys have always won?

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THIS ISSUE'S HAIKU



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MEDIA

Merchandise

Film critic and former Times Group journalist Mayur Lookhar speaks with TVE correspondent Jia Ahuja about what objectivity actually means inside a media institution — the economics of entertainment journalism, the silence around labour, and what it costs to tell the truth on a platform owned by someone else.

BY MAYUR LOOKHAR

I
"Comment on the journalistic insistence to shoehorn a certain kind of objectivity & neutrality into every narrative."

Mayur: So, basically, before I answer here, I wanted to know - these questions that you have come up with - they seem to be fantastic questions, but - what is... you know, what is the thinking behind asking these questions. Is it some kind of an ideology? That makes you ask this? You know, are you coming from some school of objective journalism? Of - you know, the fourth estate, the so called... is that how it is? Do you have a preamble about how journalism should be?

Jia: Yes, sir. And that's what we want your opinion on, like how do you think it should function? Like, there is this narrative that, you know, every story or every piece of journalism should have a certain kind of objectivity or neutrality in its perspective. So, as a journalist, what do you think?

Mayur: There is no debate, there is no debate , that any information - whether it is in the form of news, or a simple communication which you might have with a person, you know, your family & friends, say on WhatsApp group - any information that you put out there has to be objective. Specifically for the media, ideally, the media's job is to be objective.

Jia: Right.

Mayur: That is what the media was - at least was supposed to, has meant to - be through all these years, you know? From the time, you know, basically publishing started, news started. The media's job was to just be objective, neutral. Cover all aspects of a story, get quotes or verify information, put it on - in print. And without taking any side, it has to be objective & neutral, that's it. So, your job was over there. But obviously since we live in 2023, and today - especially with the advent of social media - the technological advancements & especially in the digital age... basically what happens is that the media is divided into different segments. There is broadcast media, there is traditional news media, there is digital media. So, basically, now what's happened is these so-called words, principles - now, they obviously don't hold true for - or maybe they mean different things for each & every medium.

Jia: Could you elaborate on that?

Mayur: If I were to give you an example of broadcast media - which you yourself as a young student, if you were to follow it, if you asked me what broadcast media is, what is news media today, then for three of the most successful channels it's - [sighs]

"It's not that on the Broadcast medium you're not supposed to use the 5 W's & 1 H, it's just that you have very little time. The moment you get a scoop, if it is confirmed, you play it. Then, you seek reactions. "Oh! Salman Khan has been arrested." You know, you're speaking to his lawyer, you're speaking to some other actors like Sameer Soni, who was also involved in the alleged crime." Mayur Lookhar, 2023

— MAYUR LOOKHAR, 2023

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"In the same year, Benedetto Croce characterized the ideology of the ruling party and of Mussolini as a "bizarre mixture of appeals to authority and to demagoguery, of professed reverence for the laws and of violation of the laws, of ultra-modern concepts and of musty old trash, abhorrence of culture and sterile attempts at producing a new one..." In this regard, the Italian State of the 1920s bears a striking resemblance to Modi's regime today which speaks respectfully of the Constitution while blatantly violating its spirit and essence, which appeals to ancient wisdom while displaying a contempt for modern science, which claims to exalt ancient culture while manifesting an utter philistinism in practice."

Ram Chandra Guha, 'Reading about Mussolini's Italy in Modi's India', September 2020.

— RAM CHANDRA GUHA, 'READING ABOUT MUSSOLINI'S ITALY IN MODI'S INDIA', SEPTEMBER 2020.

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Born on the 29th of July 1883 in Dovia Di Predappio, a small town in the province of Forlì in Romagna, Mussolini's early political views were heavily influenced by his father who idolized 19th century Italian nationalist figures with humanist tendencies such as Carlo Pisacane, Giuseppe Mazzini and Giuseppe Garibaldi. He studied the ideas of the philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche, the sociologist Vilfredo Pareto and the syndicalist Georges Sorel. Mussolini also later credited the Christian socialist Charles Peguy and the syndicalist Hubert Lagardelle as some of his influences.

He became active in the Italian socialist movement in Switzerland, working for the paper L'Avvenire Del Lavoratore, organizing meetings, giving speeches to workers, and serving as secretary of the Italian workers' union in Lausanne. He was briefly imprisoned and upon release, became editor of the organization's newspaper, Avanti (meaning 'forward'), the socialist newspaper, which gave him a larger megaphone and expanded his influence.

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It's all about the numbers, it's all about the viewership. You know, & that is not news. You can call it noise. But that's the way the game is played today. Because your broadcast audience is not interested in reading about the news. For that, it has its mobile phone, it can subscribe to any digital portal, & he or she will get updates. So, the question of objectivity & neutrality doesn't arise with broadcast media. You know, especially the top private media houses. Because most of them are controlled by corporates (sic). And corporates (sic) have direct or indirect linkages with the political class.

Jia: Right.

Mayur: So, while obviously it's a wonderful thing, a morality thing, that the media's job is to be objective & neutral, but is it in their hands? My question to you would be that. Basically, you just have to play along with the way the tune is being played. So, yeah, definitely from a traditional journalism point of view, at least what you are getting to see on news debates - well, news is no longer news.

Jia: Yeah, that's true.

II

"All news, regardless of intent, will always be manufactured.' Do you agree?"

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Mayur: What is the definition of a manufacturer? When you ask this question. Do you have any example of it floating in your mind right now? Then maybe I'll be able to understand. I personally never use the word manufacture for news. And since I've largely covered the entertainment beat - though I keep a general knowledge of the general beat, the political thing -

Jia: Right, of course. Could you elaborate on why you refrain from using the term?

"The concept of breaking news is far from what Broadcast channels will have you believe. Basically, often what happens is - & this is my personal experience, what I have seen when I worked at the desk for a few days - if there is any breaking news, then usually these people bank on the anchors - they [laughing] usually bank on what ANI has published, what PTI has published. You know, they will take information from there & then they will claim that these are our sources. I'm not saying that all the news items on television doesn't - aren't source based - they do have that, as well. But largely what happens is - in a newsroom, there is a breaking leg every - they expect a breaking news in every bulletin, which is not possible."

Mayur Lookhar, 2023

— MAYUR LOOKHAR, 2023

POLITICS

The First Dictator

A re-examination of Julius Caesar beyond Shakespeare's romantic portrayal — the general who conquered the Gallic tribes by exploiting their internal divisions, triggered a civil war, and earned enough enemies to be stabbed twenty-three times by his own colleagues.

BY MOULI SHARMA

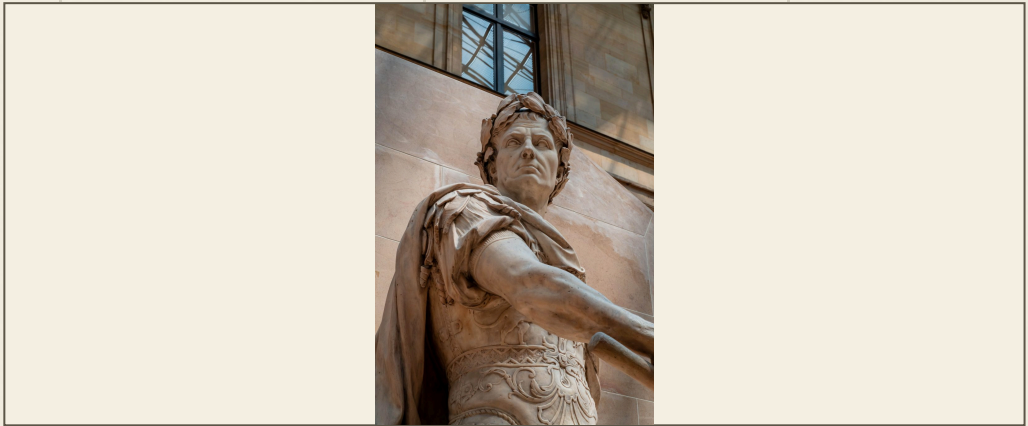


Photo: Mouli Sharma

Julius Caesar and His Many Jeopardies

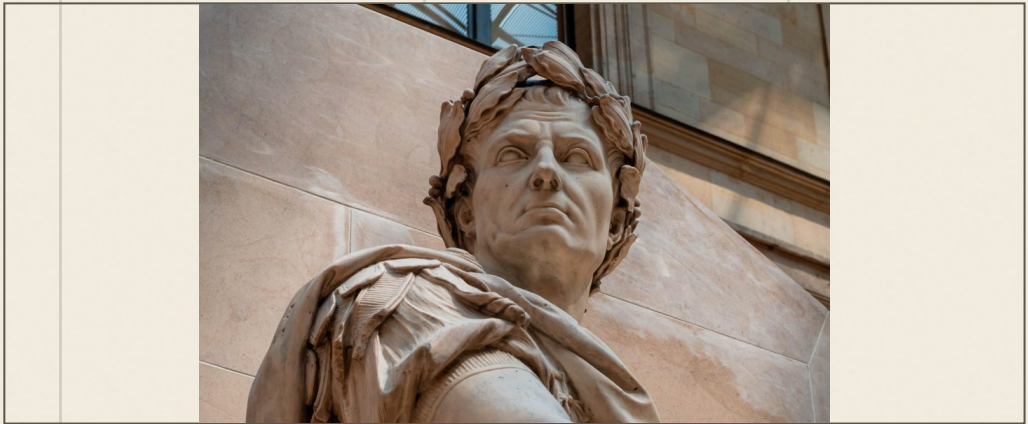


Photo: Mouli Sharma

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In 1915, he joined the Italian army and fought on the front lines, reaching the rank of corporal before being wounded and discharged from the military. The Italian Socialist party decided to oppose the war after anti militarist protestors had been killed, resulting in a general strike called Red Week. On March 23, 1919, Benito Mussolini founded the Fascist Party. The fascist movement proclaimed opposition to social class decimation and supported nationalist sentiments. He hoped to raise Italy to the levels of its great Roman past. He criticized the Italian government for weakness at the Treaty of Versailles. Capitalizing on public discontent following World War I, he organized a paramilitary unit known as the 'Black Shirts', who terrorized political opponents and helped increase Fascist influence. As Italy slipped into political chaos, Mussolini declared that only he could restore order and was given the authority in 1922 as prime minster, & thus Benito was reborn, as 'II Duce'. 1 2

'The Leader'.

Our concern with the evolution of global dictatorship traces back to the 19th century, when the word 'fascism' became a phenomenon of international concern. What a fascist, in Italy then & in India now, believes is essentially that liberal democracy is obsolete and thus regards the complete mobilization of society under a totalitarian one-party state to be necessary to prepare a nation for armed conflict and to respond effectively to economic difficulties. 3 Such a state is then to be led by a strong leader such as a dictator and its martial government is to compose of the members of the governing party – to forge national unity and maintain a stable and orderly society.

Sound familiar?
Incident over assertion.
Born 17 September 1950 in Vadnagar, Gujarat, Narendra Damodardas Modi was the third of six children and helped his father selling tea. At the age of 8, he met Lakshmanrao Inamdar, who inducted him as a junior cadet in the RSS & is known to be Modi's political 'guru'. In 1967, he completed his schooling, & a year later was married to Jashodaben, whom he soon left to pursue his political ambitions. In 1970, he became a full-time campaigner of RSS. In 1983, he completed his master's degree in political science from Gujarat University.

In 1988, Modi was elected as the organizing secretary of BJP's Gujarat unit and in 1995, became its National Secretary. In 2001, Modi was appointed the Chief Minister of Gujarat. In 2002, in the aftermath of the Godhra carnage, he submitted his resignation. However, it was rejected. Under Modi, Gujarat flourished. A number of projects for groundwater conservation were undertaken. As a result of better irrigation measures, Gujrat's yield of cotton became the largest in India. Rural electricity supply was improved. In 2013, Modi was announced as BJP's Prime Ministerial candidate and contested from Varanasi and Vadodara. Modi effectively used social media like Twitter and Facebook for his campaigns, surrounding himself with a mythic & messiahatic public image. He was sworn in on 26 May 2014, from which point on he has remained in office till date, having recontested for a successive term & won.

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You know, that's what's saleable. That's where the reader is getting value for it. In my personal view, a generalization that everything today is manufactured... no, I don't think so. Because if you read print, & even the digital news, you know, at least the premier - at least the good publications, you know, the Times group, the Indian Express, The Hindu, & The Print, Mr. Shekhar Gupta's The Print - are these good brands manufacturing content? I don't think so. You are likely to find manufacturing only in, commonly in the digital space, where the journalists are required to, you know, submit these - fulfil these targets. Ten news a day (sic). And that happens in entertainment. [Laughs].

Jia: It does.

Mayur: I can't comment on the political side because I rarely cover the political beat. At least, in terms of entertainment space, if there are targets to meet for journalists - ten articles a day - plus he or she has to attend one or two events, then in that scenario to meet those targets they will manufacture anything which is flimsy & put it up as news.

Jia: Exactly.

Jia: Well, as you say, in the entertainment industry, news is often manufactured. But in the 24x7 news channels that we have, do you think that new news pieces are available all the time? In case of their absence, what happens?

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The First Dictator - CONTINUED FROM PAGE 2

I first came across the name, Julius Caesar, while flitting through the pages of my middle school textbook three quarters of a decade ago. The great Roman ruler, romanticized in the words of Shakespeare, painted a somewhat sympathetic picture in my mind. A man slayed by his own; how could one not feel pity? I was young and impressionable, taking William's affinity for drama to be mortal truth. Julius therefore did enjoy a high position (heh) in my mind for a couple of years. Now that I am older, I feel obligated to hold myself accountable.

A mere 5 years into the rule, he was assassinated with a dagger (& then several more) through the heart by those he trusted most. And the question that both thespians & newsreaders of 44 BC have deigned to haunt us with forever, is did he deserve it?

What comes to mind when hearing the word 'Dictator' is normatively defined. Cruel, evil, merciless - the worst person ever. But its etymology is fairly neutral. It derives, obviously, from the term 'dictate,' i.e. 'to tell someone what to do.' A dictator as a political role then, in essence, is little more than managerial. Its only association to popular history is that the exemplary work of dictators like Stalin, Hitler, and Kim Jong-Un has managed to paint a prevailing mindset that dictators are inherently awful and malevolent individuals, and that much is fine. But then you see Mustafa Kemal, fondly known as Atatürk - 'father of the Turks,' a revolutionary nationalist who rose against the Ottoman Empire in the early 20th century and led Turkey on a path of modernization. You see Lee Kuan Yew, who led Singapore to independence from British rule in 1959 and elevated its agricultural economy to new heights, laying the foundation for Singapore to become one of Asia's wealthiest countries. You see more & you read more & you're forced to ask - what gives?

The modern Geo-political world has afforded too much importance to words and labels. A young girl who likes video games becomes an NLOG becomes a Pick-Me. A terrorist becomes a Prime Minister becomes a Gold Medalist becomes a World Leader. A CEO becomes a Genius becomes Revolutionary becomes a Meme. Invaders become Natives become Civilized become Developed. The Indian state of Allahabad becomes the Bharatiya state of Prayagraj. It seems that nouns, even proper ones, now carry the potential to alter the course of history.

CULTURE

Dictate

A photo essay on autocratic politics and the suppression of thought – the first resource any authoritarian strips from a people is not dignity but the capacity for independent thinking. Photographs and text by Kanika Solanki, journalism student at the University of Delhi.

BY KANIKA SOLANKI

The identifying trait of autocratic politics, the most elementary means of taking control of a people, is cutting out their resources. And the first of these to go, perhaps even before dignity & survival, is thought. And the capacity to hold on to it.



Much of Modi's life & personal background remains, while it hasn't yet been quite removed from our memory, & while those of us who do in fact possess said memory directly are still alive, subject to immense controversy. The two paragraphs above have been primarily sourced from a website called aplustopper.com, in a ready to plagiarize essay about the prime minister written for school children of age 6 through 10. An essay that opened with the words, "he waved and a million Indians joined him in the chorus which he led. He, Narendra Modi, sang the song of India's development and the road ahead."

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"India has been longing for a change since a long (sic). Freedom from corruption and communalism, education and jobs for all are some of India's top concerns. India has reposed a lot of faith in this 'son of the soil'. Let us hope Modi to be India's next 'Miracle Man':" Aplustopper user sastry (sic), Narendra Modi Essay for Students and Children in English, March 2023

— APLUSTOPPER USER SASTRY (SIC), NARENDRA MODI ESSAY FOR STUDENTS AND CHILDREN IN ENGLISH, MARCH 2023

It is here that the construction of the 'myth' (The Leader, The Führer, The Son of the Soil) begins. His lack of military ability & experience, his frivolous & demagogueruatic policies (yesterday, a crowd wearing garlands & carrying megaphones & a sound system carried a pot through the streets asking people to donate handfuls of earth for the graves of soldiers paraded through the capital's streets, another of Modi's self-proclaimed ingenious schemes for public welfare), his involvements in corruption & criminal conspiracy, his cartoonish ignorance on political or economic matters - the ill-founded joke of his international persona, all cease to matter. It is Modi's India, that begins to replicate Mussolini's Italy, even if Modi himself cannot. And one can argue that this can never be the case. That Modi's regime will always differ from that of Mussolini's fundamentally because he was democratically elected: chosen. But so was Assad. So was Machado. So was Batista.

Mussolini, Hitler, & Musharraf were all leaders that were chosen by their countries, one way or another, regardless of what name you give to the process & regardless of how stupid it makes them feel to hear it. In fact, most dictators have democratic origins, that is why they are called dictators, & not monarchs or compatriots or some other sugar-coated variation of the name, despite playing the same role.

Merchandise - CONTINUED FROM PAGE 3

Jia: [Laughs]

Mayur: So, basically the broadcast medium also has its own world. The print medium, you know, because today obviously we'll always be behind digital & broadcast. And digital is like, it's always more volume than quality. It's not that they don't give you quality - they do. But for the news - it's like fast food. It's like if you get something, you write it quick enough, & we'll update the copy later. So, if you call that as manufacturing - I mean, that could be manufacturing - but personally, it's very difficult to manufacture news. You can manufacture a debate, out of a pointless news item. With what you see on news channels these debates, they are basically manufactured content only. You know, you hold onto one particular thing & you stretch it like a chewing gum. That's how it is, ma'am. As per my limited understanding.

The problem is not that the state of Indian politics bears a closer resemblance to the autocratic state than it does to democracy, but that the structure of the modern democracy itself works parallel to its sister States: the oligarchy & the dictatorship. Business conglomerates form the oligarchal tier, the self-serving multi-party system forms the democratic one, & the majoritarian central politics & glorified Leader of state form the dictatorial one. It is not the erasure of democracy that we need to fear, but the corruption of it. Because the differences between Modi's India & Mussolini's Italy, those assertive differences that we've been putting aside till now, are not what protect our states from turning into theirs, but what prevented theirs from lasting. It is the radicalism & fast-moving catalysts absent from our broken democracy that lead to the rise of the fascist state, but they are also what lead to its demise. And it is this very absence that ensures the indefinite sustenance of our country as it stands, stagnated, while rotting it from the inside out.

In Italy, Mussolini founded the Fascist party which organized several right-wing groups into a single force. The National Democratic Alliance, a right wing conservative Indian political alliance today controls the government of India as well as the government of 15 Indian states and one Union territory. The outbreak of World War I had resulted in a surge of Italian nationalism and the war was supported by a variety of political fractions. Hindu nationalist sentiment now forms the forerunning point of the BJP's & it's sister organizations' political agenda. 'He carried out the extensive public works and reduced unemployment. The country was thriving and was convinced that he made a place in history and would take the nation to new heights, with the vision to the empire's ancient glory (sic).'

Who are these sentences about?

In 1923, the Italian government passed the Acerbo law, which transformed Italy into a single constituency. A hundred years later, the Indian government has proposed & is in the process of implementing a constitution amending act that will unify the country's composite& near continuous election cycle into a single one, cutting off chances of regional parties & recreating a system which when active, had as many as 4 states under presidential rule at a time.

We are frogs in gradually heating water, & we will boil to death before we leave.



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